A PRELIMINARY ENQUIRY INTO SPIRITUAL, RELIGIOUS AND SACRED ELECTROACOUSTIC MUSIC.

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ABSTRACT.

This paper is a consequence of an internet call I put out in January 2011, through the CEC, for electroacoustic music of a sacred/spiritual/religious nature, to be used for my radio show. It is a preliminary response to the surprisingly large number of e-mails I received. It attempts to do the following: To categorise some of the almost one hundred e-mail responses in terms of country and general type of music; to quote six of the composers who e-mailed me; to list future possible areas of enquiry in the area; to let you hear excerpts from the following works: *Requiem* Georges Forget; *Ikaro* Gary Kendall; *Homo Religiosus* Eldad Tsabary.

Composers from the following countries responded: Greece, France, Spain, Mexico, USA, Britain, Ireland, Poland, Canada, Australia, Argentina, New Zealand. Types of works ranged from: soundscape pieces that use sounds from both eastern and western sacred places; compositions In the western christian tradition especially the mass; works that reference buddhist practice; one piece based on an islamic chant; many compositions that use scripture or other religious texts; works that describe themselves generally as transcendent or spiritual; compositions that reference religion in general; pieces that refer to shamanism in both content and practice; those that imply some sort of sacred quality within sound/music itself and those that reference indigenous religious practice.

Below are a six quotes from the many e-mail correspondences.

My composition, *Ikaro*, is my most recent effort at bridging the shamanic world of spirit and ceremony with the world of technological music. This effort emerged for me after some years of study with Peruvian shamans, during which I directly experienced their healing power of their music. **Gary S Kendall**

My whole purpose in dedicating a lot of my work to religion is to find connections and to find the good in all religions (charity, love, spirituality, growth, prayer, faith, and more) **Eldad Tsabary**

I am currently working on a piece for electroacoustic and kata (bo staff) called BO - which is more Asian in its spirituality. I am preparing for my karate black belt test which should be this year and this piece is part of my process to get there. **Elizabeth Hinkle Turner**

In my cycle of four "spirit journeys", *Temple* addresses the Western aspect, *The Way of the Spirit* the Eastern one, and *The Shaman Ascending* the aboriginal. Within each of these pieces, I've used the convolution process to bring out the inner harmonic structure of the source sounds as an aural metaphor for reaching a transcendent or spiritual state. **Barry Truax**

Some of my work uses text, music or ideas that has been used in churches for religious purposes. In my music, I try to bring that sense of God into the concert hall. Other works are more about the process, imitating the sacredness of creation which is one of God's activities. I want to develop a 'sacred' recording process. **Susan Frykberg**
It's religious/spiritual but only in a very abstract, Pythagorean sense. **Bruno Degazio**

Some future possible areas of enquiry may include. developing an accessible discography: collecting papers written on the subject; encouraging further discussion in the area; developing a category scheme that has meaning and relevence.

1. REFERENCES

Gary Kendall "Bridging A Shamanic World view and Electroacoustic Art." Presented at EMS 2011, New York. To be published on ***EMS Website***. Available in draft form July 2011 on http://www.garykendall.net/publications.html

Eldad Tsabary "Eldad Tsabary mixes religions and electroacoustics purposefully." Musicworks 108 winter 2010.

Barry Truax "Journeys of the Human Spirit." To appear in The Art of Immersive Soundscapes: Social, Artistic, Environmental. P. Minevich E Waterman, eds. University of Regina Press, forthcoming.

Musical examples played

"Homo Religiosus." Eldad Tsabary. http://www.yaeldad.com/ Retrieved July 2011

"Requiem." Georges Forget. retreived http://www.pointdecoute.ca/gforget.php?lang=en. Retrieved July 2011

"Ikaro." Gary s Kendall. http://www.garykendall.net/compositions.html Retrieved July 2011

Brief biography of Author Susan Frykberg is a composer, poet and radio broadcaster who tries to balance spirituality, creativity and social justice. She has degrees in experimental music and theatre, classics and theology. She taught at Simon Fraser University with Barry Truax for seven years and has also been a guest lecturer at Auckland and Otago universities; the Ontario School of Contemporary Art and the Emily Carr School of Art in Vancouver. She currently resides in Whanganui, New Zealand. She is a member of the Canadian Music Centre and the New Zealand Music Centre(SOUNZ), a past member of The World Forum for Acoustic Ecology, a founding member of the Canadian Electroacoustic Community and has a CD Astonishing Sense..... released under Earsay Editions. www.earsay.com. In 2008, one of her works was performed in Beijing, at the Congress for the International Alliance of Women Musicians and in 2010, at the International Women Composers conference in Pennsylvania. Susan has a 25 year old son Esha. She works part-time as a chaplain for Nazareth Rest Home and has a monthly radio show on electroacoustic music on Radio New Zealand Concert. She has recently begun working with improvising musicians in her Let The Art Sing series in art galleries in New Plymouth and Whanganui, to critical acclaim